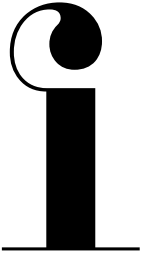


AI in Manufacturing Mode

COMPANIES WILL NEED TO UP THEIR GAME ON RESKILLING, CREATING DISRUPTIONS, MAKE INVESTMENTS AND YET DELIVER AS THEY HAVE IN THE PAST

BY KRISHNA GOPALAN



IN HIS OVER THREE-DECADE career at ABB, Sanjeev Sharma has seen the automation story from close quarters. While the various automation technologies were dis-

44 | ruptive in their own ways, AI, he thinks, has been much easier to adapt. Hard to believe, perhaps, but Sharma, ABB India's Country Head & Managing Director, says that the relative effort is lower, provided one is clear about the outcome. "It is very different from the time when we bought software or went about the process of configuring it. Insights in AI are quick and profound."

The underlying theme at each stage for manufacturing, be it Industry 2.0, 3.0, 4.0 or now 5.0 using cobots (robots that can collaborate with humans), has one common thread—**increase productivity**. The big moment for AI, according to Sharma, was around 2016 when digitalisation first started to take off. "We saw Google Maps, search engines and data-based tech harnessing insights for the future and that was potent. In many ways, the pendulum shifted then. Now, with data, the task is to put it to good use," he explains. By querying a database, answers are now available that improve decision making at the level of engineering, manufacturing and the ability to increase OEE (overall equipment effectiveness).

The pace of change through AI is expected to be so rapid that the need to adapt cannot ever be exaggerated. In that sense, if Industry 4.0 was a focus on efficiency, 5.0 could well be the neutraliser. "Efficiency is good but not at the cost of effectiveness. AI should be employed in a responsible manner, with both humans and technology co-existing," says Jayanta Banerjee, Group CIO of Tata Steel. According to him, humans will never be replaced by AI and the question is really about how to make the best use of technology.



THE UNDERLYING THEME AT EACH STAGE OF MANUFACTURING HAS ONE COMMON THREAD: **INCREASE PRODUCTIVITY**

Across manufacturing, the benefits have been significant. Jayant Acharya, Deputy Managing Director of JSW Steel, speaks of how his industry can today improve operational efficiency and productivity, reduce costs, up its quality control and enhance customer experience, with a sustainable orientation. His company is looking to augment its capacity (from 27 million tonnes per annum today to 38 million tonnes per annum by FY25). "This will leverage our three key strategic pillars [innovation, sustainability and partnerships], supported by end-to-end